Human reproduction

EVERY HUMAN BEING STARTS LIFE AS A TINY FERTILIZED EGG.

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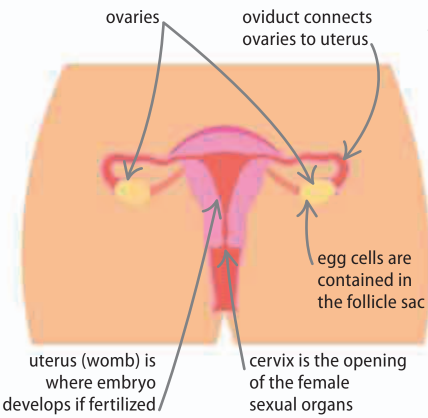
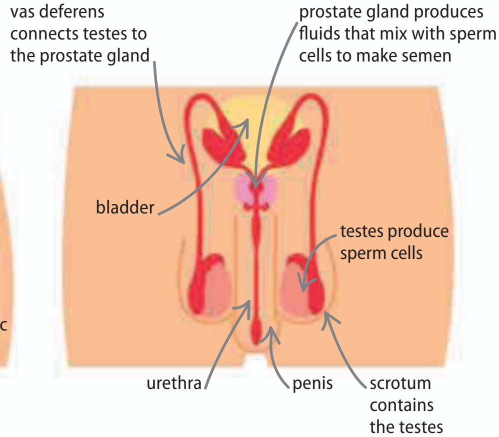
Human reproduction begins with a sperm from a man combining with an egg inside a woman's uterus to produce an embryo. The baby develops for nine months inside the mother, sustained by a temporary organ called the placenta.

Sex organs

Gametes, or sex cells, are produced in sex organs or gonads. They carry a half set of chromosomes. The man produces sperm cells in organs called testes, while a woman produces egg cells (ova) in two ovaries. The ovaries release about 400 eggs in a woman's lifetime, at a rate of one every 28 days or so, while the testes produce many millions of sperm each day. Sperm cells are delivered to the cervix during sexual intercourse, and from there they swim into the oviduct (fallopian tube) to reach the single egg.



△ **Female sex organs**
The main function of the female sex organs is to provide a place where an embryo can grow. Once it has developed enough to survive independently, the baby is born.



△ **Male sex organs**
The function of the male sex organs is to deliver sperm to the woman's uterus in a liquid called semen. The sperm cells make up about five percent of this mixture.

The record for the **most children** with the same mother is 69, born in Russia in the 18th century.

Ovulation

The process of producing and releasing an egg cell, known as ovulation, is controlled by hormones. The amount of oestrogen rises, causing one follicle in one ovary to prepare an egg cell. The ripe egg bursts from the ovary and travels into the oviduct ready to meet a sperm. The rest of the follicle then releases another hormone, progesterone, which causes the lining of the uterus to thicken, ready to receive an embryo.

▽ **Hormones and ovulation**
The egg follicle produces estrogen around day ten. A few days later, the hormone progesterone causes the lining of the uterus to thicken, so it is ready to receive a fertilized egg cell. If fertilization does not happen, the progesterone level drops, and the thickened lining of the uterus is shed as menstrual blood. The process then repeats.